article went on to add: ‘The financial clout of Tata Chemicals Chairman Darbari Seth has raised visions of centrifugal forces splitting the group.’

Though the satraps opposed any curtailment in the freedom that they enjoyed, most of the large companies calibrated their policies to implement the core recommendations contained in the Strategic Plan, without admitting to it. As Ratan says, ‘…the rest of the plan never got adopted but it got adopted by circumstances later, which is kind of interesting because when you go through what was planned for Tata Power and Tata Motors’, those policies were based on this Strategic Plan. Ratan says that Moolgaokar had originally opposed the plan. But the subsequent steps he took for the modernization of TELCO and the introduction of new models and expanding into light and passenger vehicle segments, were evidence of his having adopted the recommendations relevant to the vehicle manufacturer.

TISCO also did likewise, accelerating and expanding its modernization programme. As a magazine said in 1988: ‘In the last three years, Tata companies have initiated or proposed modernization programmes or new projects calling for investments of thousands of crore rupees, with Tata Steel’s modernization alone accounting for Rs 1,000 crore.’

Notwithstanding the satraps’ public stance, since the outlining of the plan and its adoption in TIL, there was an unprecedented momentum towards modernization and technology in the group. The sudden spurt of energy was palpable. It did not go unnoticed and became a topic of interest for Indian business leaders and the press.

As early as 1983, just two years after Ratan was appointed TIL chairman, a leading magazine captured the new momentum gripping the group. The author of the article, T.N. Ninan, commented towards the end of the article: ‘There has been speculation that at least some of this sudden splash of projects is the result of Ratan Tata taking over as chairman of Tata Industries two years ago.’

In 1988, another article summed up the effects of the transition: ‘And as India’s largest business house embarks on a massive drive to modernize and expand, more than one Tata director talks of the need for a strong corporate centre. After years of operating as a loose confederation of companies, with powerful independent professionals at the helm, this clearly suggests that an era is drawing to a close for the Tatas.